

Fake News and Its Psychological Effects: A Literature Review

Ayat Alkhatib

University of Arkansas at Little Rock

Psyc & Human Experience - 20043-993

Alex Dayer

May 8, 2026

Abstract

Fake news occurs when people are misinformed by being presented with false information as truthful. It is a widely studied topic in psychological research, as it examines how it affects humans across domains such as behavior, cognition, reasoning, decision-making, and belief systems. The three articles briefly discuss how the spread of misinformation affects thinking, behavior, and truth discernment. Overall, the studies indicate that fake news affects both cognitive and behavioral aspects, with epistemic beliefs playing a key role in determining how individuals distinguish between true and false information.

Introduction

The spread of misinformation, such as fake news, can occur in many different ways, as information is often presented falsely. Social media is a common source of misinformation. Misleading content can spread daily, and misinformation has become a common aspect of online communication. A common example that has been spreading recently is the hantavirus. Some individuals are uncertain about the truth regarding the virus; some claim that society may experience another pandemic, while others disagree. This is one of the most common examples of misinformation. Misinformation can create fear and reinforce false beliefs.

Researchers study how individuals are affected by the misinformation they hear, read, or share. People do not always evaluate information logically. This highlights the importance of understanding reasoning, decision-making, belief systems, and the perception of truth.

Epistemic Beliefs and Fake News Discernment

The study suggested a connection between dark personality traits and the dark factor of personality. The researchers decided to use a repeated-measures experimental design by presenting participants with six accurate news posts and six fake news posts and asking them to rate. Researchers concluded that epistemic beliefs and dark personality traits reduce the ability to distinguish fake news from real news (Rudloff & Appel, 2023).

COVID-19 Misinformation and Behavioral Effects

The study examines aspects of exposure to fake news about COVID-19, including how false memories affect health behavior, behavioral response, and whether they become more aware when warned about fake news. In this trial, participants were randomly assigned to one of four warning conditions. The study concluded that exposure to COVID-19 misinformation has a

measurable effect on health behaviors and was not significantly reduced by general warnings (Greene & Murphy, 2021).

Deliberation and Truth Discernment in Fake News

The study examines whether deliberation helps individuals distinguish truth from false information. The experiment involved participants reading headlines and reviewing them twice. One condition involved time pressure and a memory load, while the other condition involved no time pressure and no memory load. Researchers concluded that deliberation increased participants' ability to distinguish true from false information across different headlines (Bago & Rand, 2020).

Comparison of Findings Across Studies

The purpose of these studies is to examine whether individuals fall for fake news. One shared focus across the studies is how fake news affects behavior. The experiments demonstrate that exposure to fake news in different contexts has an effect on individuals' behavior (Rudloff & Appel, 2023; Greene & Murphy, 2021; Bago & Rand, 2020).

The studies investigate effects, including behavior, reasoning, and belief systems. Article 1 focuses on reasoning and cognition. Article 2 focuses on how exposure to COVID-19 misinformation affects health behavior. Lastly, Article 3 focuses on belief systems, specifically how individuals exposed to fake news form judgments and evaluate truth.

Overall, the concept of fake news in psychology is a complex topic that affects individuals in different ways, including mental processes, social behavior, and belief systems. This highlights the need for further research on fake news and improving psychological awareness (Rudloff & Appel, 2023; Greene & Murphy, 2021; Bago & Rand, 2020).

Limitations and Future Research

There is always a limitation to any study. In Article 1, participants were between the ages of 18 and 78, and their educational backgrounds varied (Rudloff & Appel, 2023). This may influence individuals' ability to differentiate between true and false news when presented with news posts. Differences in age and experience with media exposure may also have an effect. Future research could focus on using more demographically similar groups rather than a wide age range (Rudloff & Appel, 2023).

The gender distribution of participants may be a limitation of the study. Female participants nearly doubled male participants (Greene & Murphy, 2021). Because gender differences may influence decision-making, this imbalance could affect how participants responded across conditions. A future study could ensure a more balanced gender distribution across all experimental conditions.

Participants were divided into two groups: one under time pressure and one without, and both groups reviewed headlines twice. An improvement for future research would be to control conditions more evenly across groups. This would help ensure that differences in performance are due to deliberation rather than differences in task structure (Bago & Rand, 2020).

Conclusion

Fake news can occur frequently and has an effect on individuals' behavior, cognition, and belief systems. The three articles emphasize how reasoning processes are involved when individuals are presented with fake news, the effect of false information on health-related behavior, and how belief systems influence how people evaluate and form judgments based on information. The concept of fake news is a complex and important topic in psychology, as it demonstrates how society can be influenced by misinformation across different domains.

References

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